the case, President Kennedy had cancelled follow-on strikes. Brigade 2506 embarked for Cuba from Puerto Cabezas in Nicaragua aboard the six ships of the Cuban Expeditionary Force. General Luis Somoza arrived to wave them off and request they bring him back a couple of hairs from Castro's beard. Each ship was designated a US destroyer as escort, while the carrier USS *Essex* waited ready with its complement of Douglas A-4 Skyhawk attack aircraft.

All those involved in Operation Zapata – in the CIA, Brigade 2506, and the United States military – fully understood that air superiority over the landing sites was a prerequisite for the success of the amphibious assault. President Kennedy seemingly did not. This was despite having been briefed by the CIA on this crucial point. When it dawned upon him, on 17 April, that a new wave of B-26 strikes was imminent, he ordered the bombing to be halted. Various officials were unable to persuade him that he was making a serious mistake.

Three landing sites were chosen on or near the Bay of Pigs; the main one at Playa Giron. As the President had insisted, the operation was conducted at night. To compound the difficulties, the landing parties quickly discovered that the CIA had failed to identify coral reefs off the coastline. This obstacle helped delay establishment of the bridgehead and meant the CEF ships were exposed to daylight air attack. It was soon apparent that the Cuban air force had not been destroyed. And despite some success from anti-aircraft fire, the troops of Brigade 2506 were exposed to attacking B-26 bombers, Sea Fury fighters, and T-33 jets.

Fidel Castro immediately grasped the tactical imperative of preventing consolidation of the beachhead. One of his first acts was to telephone his chief pilot, Captain Enrique 'Chico' Carreras, and tell him: 'Chico, you must sink those ships for me. Don't let those ships go.'[51] When dawn rose, Captain Carreras's Sea Fury succeeded in crippling one of the commercial freighters, the *Houston;* and on his second sortie, attacked the *Rio Escondido*, Brigade 2506's main supply ship. A key part of Operation Zapata was for the brigade to capture two nearby airfields to provide air support from within Cuba itself. The aircraft fuel for this was carried on the *Rio Escondido*, which also transported much of the ammunition, food, and